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CROSS & CHURCH

STUDY GUIDE • 5 OF 5

redemption and new creation

LUKE, ACTS, ROMANS, REVELATION

// START HERE

Welcome to Cross and Church

Welcome to Cross and Church. Over seven weeks we follow the story from the Last Supper to new creation: the cross, the empty tomb, the Spirit at Pentecost, a persecutor made an apostle, Paul's account of grace, and the closing vision of Revelation. We read for what the text says, ask honest questions and leave each week with one step to try. Christians understand some of these passages in different ways, so we will listen carefully and kindly, and keep returning to the text.

◆ 01 How a session works

90 MIN

The same rhythm every week, so the group can relax into it.

GATHER · 10 MIN

Follow up on last week's step. Did you do it?

READ · 10 MIN

Scripture read aloud, then notes.

DISCUSS · 35 MIN

Questions, not a lecture. Everyone speaks.

ACT · 15 MIN

One step, one outward habit, then prayer.

◆ 02 What you need

BRING

- ◆ A Bible in a translation you trust
- ◆ This guide and a pen
- ◆ Anything else

BETWEEN MEETINGS

- ◆ A few minutes a day with the passage
- ◆ One step to act on
- ◆ One person to tell

◆ 03 About the passages

This guide gives **references only** and does not print Bible text, so read from your own Bible. If you paste text into a page, use a public-domain translation such as the KJV or WEB. Old Testament references use Hebrew-Bible chapter and verse numbering; where an English Bible differs, the English reference is in parentheses. This guide has 7 sessions, in canon order, as part of a five-guide journey from Genesis to Revelation.

// THE FRAME

Our group

Small, steady and weekly. Fixing these early is what lets people open up.

SIZE

6-12

people. Small enough that everyone speaks.

RHYTHM

Weekly

same day, time and place.

SEASON

7

weeks with a steady membership, then regroup.

01 Details

DAY · TIME

Day, time

PLACE

Address or room

LEADER

Name

FACILITATOR
ROTATION

Who leads which weeks

SEASON

Start – end date

CHILDCARE /
FOOD

Plan

GROUP CHAT

Link or name

OPEN / CLOSED

Closed for the season

NEXT SEASON

When we regroup

02 Roster

#	NAME	CONTACT	PRAYER OR CARE NOTE
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			
7			
8			
9			
10			

// AGREED TOGETHER

Our ground rules

Write them, read them aloud in week one, and sign. Edit freely: these are starting points, not commandments.

- 1 Show up and stay for the whole season.
- 2 What is shared here stays here.
- 3 Everyone speaks; no one dominates.
- 4 We may challenge one another kindly, and we agree to be challenged.
- 5 Let Scripture lead; opinions come second.
- 6 Pray for each other between meetings.
- 7 Your own rule

PHRASES FOR CHALLENGING KINDLY

- ◆ “Can you say more about that?”
- ◆ “What does the text say?”
- ◆ “What would it cost you to do that?”
- ◆ Your own phrase

WHEN A RULE IS BROKEN

How we will handle it: who speaks to whom, and how soon.

◆ We agree

Initials and date.

NAME

INITIALS

DATE

// CHOOSE HOW YOU READ

Four ways to study a passage

This guide assigns a method to each session. Change it if your group prefers another.

METHOD 1

Inductive

- ◆ Observe: what does it say?
- ◆ Interpret: what does it mean?
- ◆ Apply: what does it ask of me?

Best for: close reading

METHOD 2

Discovery Bible Study

- ◆ What does it say?
- ◆ What does it say about God? About people?
- ◆ What will I obey?
- ◆ Whom will I tell?

Best for: groups new to the Bible

METHOD 3

Lectio divina

- ◆ Read: a short passage, slowly
- ◆ Meditate: one phrase
- ◆ Pray: respond to God
- ◆ Rest: be still, then share

Best for: prayerful, quieter weeks

METHOD 4

Short accountability

- ◆ Did I do what I said?
- ◆ What did I read this week?
- ◆ Where did I struggle?
- ◆ Whom did I tell or serve?

Best for: pairs, or the opening of any session

◆ Methods in this guide

This guide uses Discovery, Inductive, Lectio divina. Short accountability opens every session in the “Gather” step.

// 7 WEEKS

Our season at a glance

The arc is set; adjust as you go.

WEEK	PASSAGE	THEME	METHOD	LEADS
1	Luke 22:7–23	The Last Supper	Lectio divina	Name
2	Luke 23	The cross	Inductive	Name
3	Luke 24:1–35	The empty tomb and the road to Emmaus	Discovery	Name
4	Acts 1:6–11; 2	The Spirit comes	Inductive	Name
5	Acts 9	Saul becomes Paul	Discovery	Name
6	Romans 3:21–26; 8:1–17	Grace and new life	Lectio divina	Name
7	Revelation 21:1–8; 22:1–5	New creation	Discovery	Name

LAST WEEK OF THE SEASON

Celebrate, review what changed, and decide whether to continue, regroup or multiply. Each guide in this set continues the story in canon order, from Genesis to Revelation.

// SESSION 1 OF 7 • LECTIO DIVINA

The Last Supper

LUKE 22:7-23 • LEADS: NAME • DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Welcome everyone. Read the ground rules aloud (page 4) and share names.

WARM-UP

What meal do you most remember sharing?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Luke 22:7-23 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

LUKE 22:7-23

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** What does Jesus say over the bread and the cup (22:17-20)? What does he say about the one who will betray him (22:21-23)?

- 2 **INTERPRET** What does Jesus mean by “do this in remembrance of me” (22:19), and what does the meal point forward to (22:15-18)?

- 3 **APPLY** What does it look like to remember Jesus in your daily life, not only at a meal?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Christian traditions understand the Lord’s Supper differently. What do we all hear in this passage, even where we disagree about the meal?

◆ 04 This week’s step

10 MIN

Share a meal with someone this week, give thanks, and tell someone one thing you find hard to surrender.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Share a meal with someone lonely or in need.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Luke 22:14-23.

DAY 2

Write what you find hard to surrender.

DAY 3

Pray with the bread and cup in mind.

DAY 4

Do this week’s step.

// SESSION 2 OF 7 · INDUCTIVE

The cross

LUKE 23 · LEADS: ·

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

What do you do when you do not know what to say to someone who is suffering?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Luke 23 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

LUKE 23

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

1 OBSERVE Who is present at the cross, and what does each person say or do (23:26–27, 23:35–43, 23:44–49)?

2 INTERPRET What do Jesus' words to the criminal (23:42–43) and the centurion's words (23:47) say about who Jesus is?

3 APPLY Where do you see yourself among the people at the cross? What do you want to say to Jesus?

4 CHALLENGE KINDLY Christians explain what the cross accomplishes in different ways. What do we all affirm from this passage, and how do we keep from turning it into a debate?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Spend ten quiet minutes this week with this passage and tell someone what you notice.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Support someone suffering unjustly: a prisoner, a refugee, or someone grieving.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5–10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Luke 23:32–49.

DAY 2

Write what you notice about Jesus.

DAY 3

Pray in silence.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 3 OF 7 · DISCOVERY

The empty tomb and the road to Emmaus

LUKE 24:1-35 · LEADS: ·

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

Tell about a surprise that was too good to believe at first.

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Luke 24:1-35 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

LUKE 24:1-35

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** What do the women find, and how do the apostles respond (24:1-12)? What do the two travelers say, and when do they recognize Jesus (24:13-35)?

- 2 **INTERPRET** Why do their hearts burn as Jesus explains the Scriptures (24:27, 24:32)? Why might they recognize him in the breaking of bread (24:30-31)?

- 3 **APPLY** Where do you walk with Jesus without recognizing him? What would help you see?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Some find the resurrection hard to believe. How do we make room for doubt and faith in the same room?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

What will I obey? Share the good news with someone by telling your own story of meeting Jesus. Whom will I tell?

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Share good news with someone who needs it: invite someone to a meal or gathering.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Luke 24:13-35.

DAY 2

Write where you have recognized Jesus.

DAY 3

Pray with open hands.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 4 OF 7 · INDUCTIVE

The Spirit comes

ACTS 1:6–11; 2 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

Describe a community where you felt you belonged.

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Acts 1:6–11; 2 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

ACTS 1:6–11; 2

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** What does Jesus tell the disciples before he leaves (1:6–11)? What happens at Pentecost (2:1–13), and how does the crowd respond to Peter (2:37–41)?

- 2 **INTERPRET** What marks the life of the first believers (2:42–47)? What does it show about who Jesus is?

- 3 **APPLY** Which of the four habits in 2:42 (teaching, fellowship, breaking bread, prayer) is strongest in our group, and which needs to grow?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Churches differ about the Spirit and spiritual gifts, and the Lord's Supper. How can we talk about our experiences with respect for each other?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Choose one of the four practices in 2:42 to grow this week and tell someone.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Share your possessions or time with someone in need, as in 2:44–45.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5–10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Acts 2:42–47.

DAY 2

Write which habit you would grow.

DAY 3

Pray for the church.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 5 OF 7 · DISCOVERY

Saul becomes Paul

ACTS 9 · LEADS: ·

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

Who changed your mind about something big?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Acts 9 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

ACTS 9

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

1 **OBSERVE** What was Saul doing, and what happens on the road (9:1-9)? What does Ananias fear and what does God say (9:10-16)?

2 **INTERPRET** Why might the Lord ask Ananias and Barnabas to receive Saul (9:17-19, 9:26-27)? What does the story say about change?

3 **APPLY** Who might God be asking you to welcome who frightens you? Who welcomed you?

4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** How do we recognize change in people who harmed others, while taking safety and trust seriously?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

What will I obey? Reach out to someone who is new or hard to welcome. Whom will I tell?

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Welcome someone with a difficult past: volunteer with a re-entry program or a welcome team.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Acts 9:10-19.

DAY 2

Write who you find hard to welcome.

DAY 3

Pray for them.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 6 OF 7 · LECTIO DIVINA

Grace and new life

ROMANS 3:21–26; 8:1–17 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

What does it feel like to be forgiven?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Romans 3:21–26; 8:1–17 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

ROMANS 3:21–26; 8:1–17

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- OBSERVE** What does Paul say about righteousness apart from the law, and about how people are put right with God (3:21–26)? What does 8:1 declare?

- INTERPRET** What does it mean to live by the Spirit and be children of God (8:5, 8:14–17)? How is this different from fear (8:15)?

- APPLY** Where do you live as if you were still condemned? What would living as a child of God change?

- CHALLENGE KINDLY** Christians read Romans differently on faith, works and God's choice. What do we all hear in these verses, and where do we need to listen to one another?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

Each morning this week say one line of Romans 8 aloud and name one thing you are free from or free to do.

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Offer someone else grace in a concrete way: forgive a small debt or give an encouraging word.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5–10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Romans 8:1–17.

DAY 2

Write what condemns you.

DAY 3

Pray as a child to a Father.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// SESSION 7 OF 7 · DISCOVERY

New creation

REVELATION 21:1-8; 22:1-5 · LEADS: NAME · DATE

◆ 01 Gather & follow up

10 MIN

Did you do last week's step? What happened?

WARM-UP

What would your ideal day in a perfect world look like?

◆ 02 Read

10 MIN

Read Revelation 21:1-8; 22:1-5 aloud twice, by different voices, in a translation your group trusts.

REVELATION 21:1-8; 22:1-5

◆ 03 Discuss

35 MIN

- 1 **OBSERVE** What does John see in 21:1-4, and what does God say (21:3-5)? What is in the city and what is missing (22:1-5)?

- 2 **INTERPRET** How do these images connect to the beginning of Genesis (a river, a tree, God walking with people)? What do they promise?

- 3 **APPLY** What does this vision change about how you face grief, injustice or fear now? What would you want to start living as a sign of it?

- 4 **CHALLENGE KINDLY** Revelation is read in many ways. How can we hold questions about how to read it, while we agree on the hope these chapters offer?

◆ 04 This week's step

10 MIN

What will I obey? Choose one way to live as a sign of the new creation this week, and plan what you will do after the season ends. Whom will I tell?

I WILL...

◆ 05 Beyond the group

5 MIN

Plan a service or restoration project with your group: care for a place or people in need.

◆ 06 Between sessions

5-10 MIN A DAY

DAY 1

Read Revelation 21:1-8.

DAY 2

Write what you long for.

DAY 3

Pray for what you hope for.

DAY 4

Do this week's step.

// PERSONAL REFLECTION

Five days, five short moments

The strongest measured predictor of spiritual growth is reading and reflecting on your own between meetings. Ten minutes is enough. Use the passage from your next session.

◆ 01 Read

10 MIN

Read the week's passage slowly, once. Note the reference.

◆ 02 Notice

10 MIN

Write one line: what stands out?

◆ 03 Ask

10 MIN

Write one question you would ask God about it.

◆ 04 Do

10 MIN

Take this week's step. What happened?

◆ 05 Pray

10 MIN

Pray for the person or place outside the group.

BRING TO NEXT SESSION

One thing you noticed, one question, one result from your step.

// TOGETHER AND BEYOND

Prayer requests

NAME	REQUEST	DATE	ANSWERED

◆ Beyond the group

An outward-facing habit keeps the group from turning inward: people and places we pray for or serve outside the circle.

WHO OR WHERE	PRAY / SERVE	WHEN	DONE

◆ Season project (optional)

One thing we do together for others.

Plan a service day together: serve alongside a church or nonprofit in your community, then share a meal afterward.

Project, date, who is leading ·

// FOR THE LEADER

Leader's notes

The leader guides; the group discovers. Ask, listen, and resist teaching the whole passage.

BEFORE

- ◆ Read the passage twice and note your own questions
- ◆ Pick the method and rehearse the four questions
- ◆ Pray for each person by name

AFTER

- ◆ Text a note to anyone who was quiet
- ◆ Log the steps people named
- ◆ Your own follow-up

◆ 01 Timing guide

90 MIN

PART	MIN	NOTES
Gather & follow up	10	<u>Notes</u>
Open in prayer	3	<u>Notes</u>
Read	10	<u>Notes</u>
Discuss	35	<u>Notes</u>
This week's step	10	<u>Notes</u>
Beyond the group · prayer	12	<u>Notes</u>
Buffer	10	<u>Notes</u>

◆ 02 Hard moments in this guide

DIFFERENCES ON THE LORD'S SUPPER

Traditions understand the meal differently. Invite everyone to say what they hear in the text and what they hold in common, without debating.

ATONEMENT AND GRACE

Christians explain what the cross accomplishes and how Romans 3 and 8 fit together in different ways. Keep to the passages and hold the questions open.

REVELATION

Revelation is read in many ways. Stay with the vision of new creation, allow questions, and avoid timelines or predictions.

◆ 03 Session notes

WHY THIS STRUCTURE

Groups reliably build belonging and forgiveness, but showing up does not by itself deepen Bible knowledge or growth. The design leans on discussion, written ground rules, a step to act on, personal reflection between meetings and an outward habit. The 6–12 size and 8–12 week season are practitioner advice, not a measured result.

// SESSION BY SESSION

What to watch for

A short note for each week. Edit freely.

WEEK	PASSAGE	WATCH FOR
1	Luke 22:7–23	Communion differences may cause tension. Invite everyone to name what they hold in common, and avoid debating the meaning of the meal.
2	Luke 23	Do not hurry; allow quiet. Avoid graphic detail beyond the text. Some traditions use different language for the atonement, so hold it gently.
3	Luke 24:1–35	Invite doubt honestly; no one should feel pressure to state certainty.
4	Acts 1:6–11; 2	Spiritual gifts and the Lord's Supper are divisive subjects; avoid taking sides and stay with what the text says.
5	Acts 9	Do not imply that victims must trust those who harmed them; safety and trust are different things.
6	Romans 3:21–26; 8:1–17	Romans touches heavily debated topics. Keep to the passage and hold questions open without taking sides.
7	Revelation 21:1–8; 22:1–5	Revelation is read in many ways. Stay with the vision of new creation, avoid timelines and predictions, and use this last session to review the season and plan what is next.